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THEATRE ARTS

COSTUME

Wardrobe: The Plot, the Quick Change and the Run

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

What happens to costumes after the fitting: the wardrobe plot, dressers, quick changes, laundry and the care of a company's clothes through a run.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- wardrobe plot
- quick changes
- dressers
- laundry
- repairs

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The wardrobe plot

The wardrobe plot lists every costume piece, its owner, the scene it appears in, where it is preset and who is responsible for it. It is the costume department's equivalent of the prop table, and it lives in the wings where it is used.

Label everything, inside and out, with the character and the actor. Two black skirts are identical until the wrong one is on stage.

Quick changes

A quick change is a small piece of theatre staged in the wings. Plan it: where the actor stands, who undoes what, which garments are pre-opened and which are on a numbered chair, and how many seconds it takes. Rehearse it with a stopwatch, in costume, at least three times.

If a change takes longer than the music or the scene it happens under, the design is wrong and should be changed. Do not solve a design problem with speed.

Dressers and the show call

Every dresser needs the plot, a torch, a sewing kit, safety pins, stain remover and a clothes brush. The dresser's job is to make the actor ready and calm; a dresser who is shouting is a second emergency.

Preset before the half. After the show, every piece goes back to its place, not to a pile: the next performance begins the moment the last one ends.

Care, repairs and the end of the run

Wash according to the fabric, not the schedule. Delicate pieces are spot-cleaned; white shirts are washed nightly; heavy costumes are aired. Keep a repair log, and mend on the day the damage is found - a torn hem on Monday is a torn hem in the photograph on Friday.

At the end of the run, catalogue what the department owns, clean and store it, and return borrowed items with a note of thanks. The next production will need the same goodwill.

The dress rehearsal and the notes

The dress rehearsal is a technical event wearing costumes. Watch it from the wings, with the wardrobe plot in your hand, and write down every change that did not work, every piece that arrived late and every actor who could not move properly. Those notes are worth more than any number of notes about appearance.

After the dress, sit with each actor for two minutes. Ask what the costume stops them doing. An actor who cannot raise an arm, sit down or cross the stage quickly will tell you, and they are right. Alter the costume, not the blocking.

Between performances, check the rail before the half: every piece present, every piece clean, every repair done. A missing glove on a Saturday night is a costume department problem, not an actor's, and the audience will not know the difference.

A wardrobe on no budget

Three rails and a cupboard will dress a department if the pieces are chosen, not accumulated. Build a core: five men's suits in different sizes, ten white shirts, five dark skirts, five blouses, two academic gowns, a rail of neutral dresses, and a box of scarves, belts and shoes. Hire or make the period pieces per show.

Buy at the market, not the boutique, and buy with a tape measure. Alteration is cheaper than purchase, and a garment that fits the actor will read as expensive from the third row whatever it cost.

The costume store

Store on hangers, not in bags: cloth needs air, and a bin bag is where costumes go to smell. Fold knits, hang tailoring, box shoes in pairs with the size written on the heel, and keep a labelled box for each production.

Photograph every stored costume on a hanger against a plain wall and keep the photograph with the inventory. The next designer will choose from the photograph rather than from memory, and the store will finally be used.

Exercises

1. Write a wardrobe plot for a five-character, three-scene play.
2. Stage and time a quick change of three garments, then redesign it to take half the time.
3. Draw up a laundry and repair schedule for a two-week run.

Where to read more

Rosemary Ingham and Liz Covey, The Costume Designer's Handbook (1992)

Mary Fernald and Eileen Shenton, Costume Design and Making (1965)

Mrs. Aria, Costume: Fanciful, Historical and Theatrical (1906)

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